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Operation Mousetrap

During the latter part of 1991, we conceived a series of counterinfiltration operations called 'Mousetrap'. In these operations we adopted a dynamic matrix of positions in tiers that we changed frequently. As a result, we achieved quite spectacular results. Our success story was covered prominently in *Frontline* magazine of 31 January 1992.

In Operation Mousetrap we had one of our finest counterinfiltration actions. It began very unexpectedly. On the morning of 27 November '91, when I was having breakfast, I heard the sounds of a shooting engagement from across the Jhelum river. I asked my brigade major, R.P.S. (Rajpal) Mann, to find out what was happening. He enquired from the battalion on the LoC if there was an encounter going on with terrorists somewhere. They said no. The exchange of fire continued nonetheless and from the sound of gunshots, it did not appear to be happening too far away. I therefore decided to move with my protection party and quick reaction team (QRT) towards the action site. 'Let's go,' I ordered Captain V.K. Singh, the brigade education officer, as our convoy sped off. VK was officiating as the general staff officer (intelligence) of the brigade. We crossed the bridge over the Jhelum and had barely gone a kilometre or so when we saw twenty-five to thirty soldiers running down the road towards us. When we asked them about the firing, they displayed total ignorance. I almost lost my shirt at their lack of interest, but it was amusing to learn that in the middle of this battle, these soldiers were going through a point-to-point map-reading test! I asked if they were carrying any ammunition along with their rifles. On getting a positive nod, I asked them to hop on to the protection